Q. What does Ram mean to you and to India?
Lord Ram is the eternal king and, as the *Maryada Purushottam*, an archetype to follow for all leaders. Throughout history, royal dynasties across the subcontinent have claimed to be inspired by Lord Ram and Ram Rajya.

Q. What was your biggest takeaway from doing the documentary?
A lovely line by archaeologist K.K. Muhammed who said, "Babar was a foreigner from Uzbekistan, and I am an Indian Muslim. What do I have to do with the foreigner?" This dispute over the Babri Masjid was not a Hindu-Muslim issue, it was an Indian-foreigner one, and the rebuilding of the temple was, in that sense, a project of national consciousness.

Q. What drew you to mythology?
Hinduism and the Dharmic way gave us a unique balance of tradition and liberalism. If you choose only liberalism, as the West has, you face problems like loneliness, decadence and chaos. If you choose only tradition, then you have problems like in the Middle East, with no place for women's or LGBT rights. Finding a balance between the two is key. Ancient Hinduism shows us you can have the best of both worlds.

Q. What's next from Amish?
There is the fifth book of the *Ram Chandra* series, which will connect the series (released between 2015 and 2022) to the *Shiva Trilogy* (released between 2010 and 2013). It's been a long journey and, as I wrote in one of my books, "the journey isn't truly over until you return to where it all began." The title of the fifth book, *Rise of Meluha*, makes the theme clear.

–with Amit Dixit



KEEPING THE FAITH

Working on his new documentary, JioCinema's *Ram Janmabhoomi: Return of a Splendid Sun*, was a divine experience for **Amish**

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH